Adoption and Ethical Implications of Generative AI Tools in Academic Reference Services

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Abstract. Academic libraries are beginning to adopt generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools to support reference services, literature discovery, and research consultation. This study examines how academic reference librarians in Zamboanga City evaluate, adopt, and govern these tools, and how they reconcile gains in efficiency with concerns about accuracy, attribution, privacy, and equitable access. Using a mixed-methods design, the study combines a survey of reference librarians with semi-structured interviews and a review of institutional policies. The expected contribution is a practical adoption framework that aligns generative AI use with professional ethics and the information needs of graduate students.

Keywords: generative AI; academic libraries; reference services; information ethics; AI governance

1. Introduction

Generative AI tools have moved quickly from experimental curiosity to everyday infrastructure in higher education. Students use conversational assistants to refine research questions, summarize sources, and draft literature reviews, while librarians are asked to guide responsible use without compromising academic integrity. The reference desk is therefore a critical site for observing both the promise and the risk of these technologies.

Existing studies describe librarian attitudes toward AI, but fewer examine the day-to-day decisions that shape adoption: which tools are licensed, how answers are verified, what data may be entered into third-party systems, and how students are taught to disclose AI assistance. This concept paper argues that adoption decisions are fundamentally ethical decisions, and that a workable framework must be grounded in the actual practices of reference librarians.

The study addresses three questions: (1) Which generative AI tools are currently used in academic reference services, and for what tasks? (2) What accuracy, privacy, and attribution concerns do librarians report? (3) Which institutional policies and professional practices support responsible adoption?

2. Review of Related Literature

2.1 Generative AI in Reference Work

Recent literature positions generative AI as both an assistant and a disruption. Proponents emphasize faster discovery, improved accessibility, and the ability to scaffold searches for novice researchers. Critics point to fabricated citations, uneven coverage of local and non-English sources, and the risk that confident prose masks weak evidence.

2.2 Ethical and Professional Concerns

Professional codes emphasize accuracy, confidentiality, intellectual freedom, and equitable access. Generative AI complicates each: prompts may contain personal data, outputs may reproduce bias, and subscription tiers may create a two-speed service for students who can afford premium tools. Attribution is especially contested because the boundary between assistance and authorship is difficult to observe.

2.3 Institutional Readiness

Studies of technology adoption in libraries stress the importance of staff training, clear policy, and trusted channels for reporting problems. Where policies are absent, librarians often develop informal rules that vary across desks and shifts. This study treats those informal rules as important evidence of how ethical judgment is exercised in practice.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

The study uses an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design. A cross-sectional survey of reference librarians provides a broad picture of tool use and concerns. Follow-up interviews with purposively selected participants explore how decisions are made and justified. A document review of university and library policies situates individual practices within institutional guidance.

3.2 Data Gathering Procedure

Participants will be recruited from academic libraries in Region IX through official library networks and direct invitations. The survey will be administered online over four weeks and will cover tool use, frequency, perceived accuracy, privacy practices, and policy awareness. Interviews will be conducted in person or online, audio-recorded with consent, and transcribed verbatim. Policy documents will be collected from institutional websites and official records.

Survey data will be analyzed using descriptive statistics and cross-tabulations. Interview transcripts will be coded thematically, with an initial codebook derived from the literature and refined through constant comparison. Quantitative and qualitative findings will be integrated in a joint display that compares reported practices with stated concerns.

3.3 Ethical Considerations

Participation is voluntary and confidential. Informed consent will be obtained before each interview, and identifying details will be removed from transcripts. Data will be stored on encrypted institutional storage and retained only for the duration of the study. The protocol will be submitted to the University Research Ethics Committee before data collection begins.

4. Expected Outcomes and Contribution

The study expects to produce three outputs: a profile of generative AI use in academic reference services, a grounded account of ethical concerns and coping practices, and a practical adoption framework for library administrators. The framework will identify minimum safeguards for accuracy, privacy, attribution, and equitable access, together with staff training and review mechanisms.

By connecting policy to everyday practice, the study aims to help libraries adopt generative AI deliberately rather than by default. It also contributes to the broader conversation on how professional ethics can guide the use of AI in public-service institutions.

5. References

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